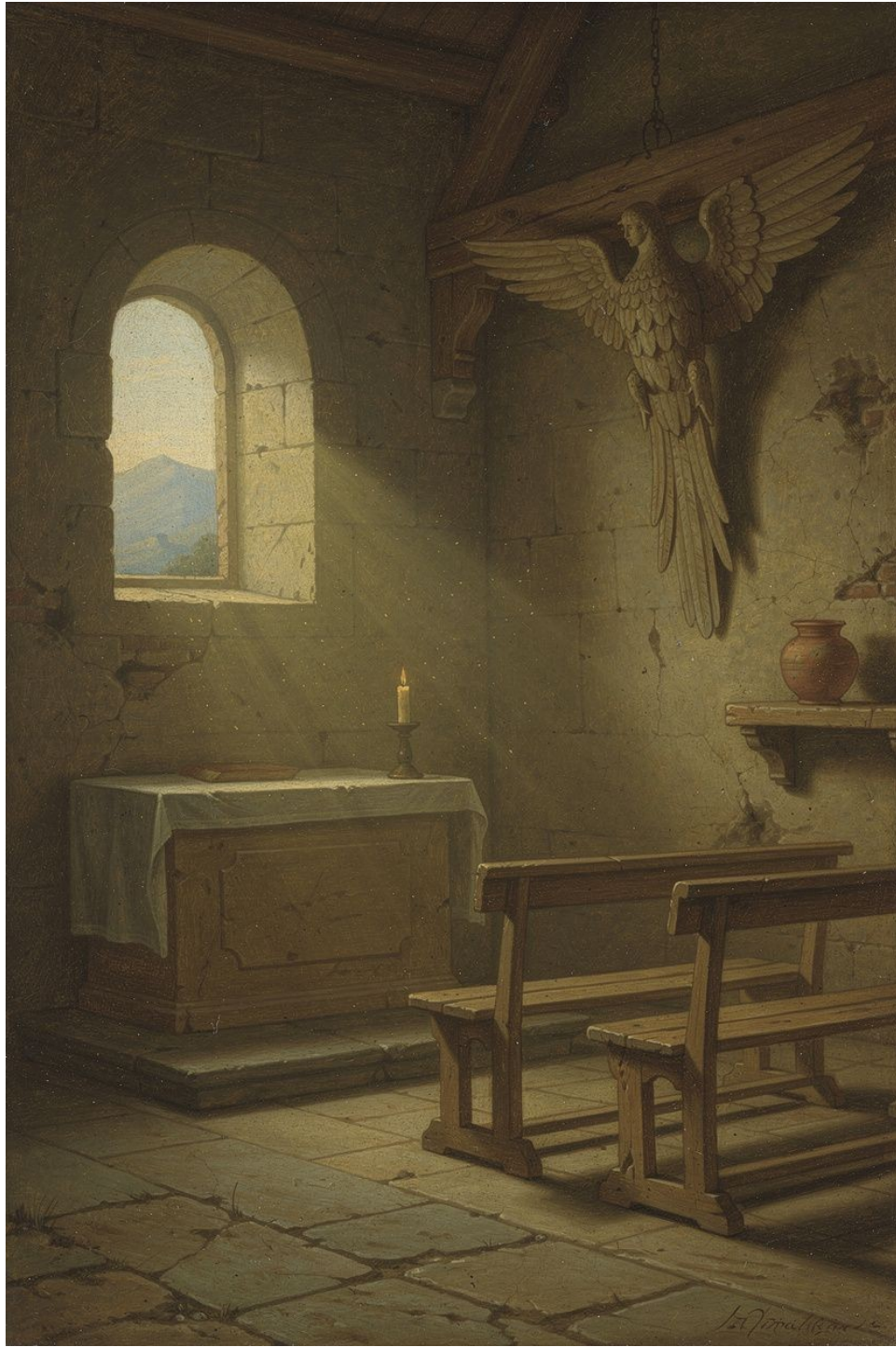




The Ladder with Six Wings

WisdomForge Booklet — Ages 5–10

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About This Book

A long time ago, a friar named Bonaventure loved two things at once: thinking carefully, and climbing toward God with his whole heart. He did not think those two loves had to fight. He thought they could walk together, like two feet on one path.

This booklet is a map of that path. Bonaventure said the world is a ladder. You do not throw the ladder away. You climb it. First you look at trees and light and bread. Then you look inside, at memory and wondering and wanting. Then you look at Jesus, who is the middle of the ladder. Then you rest in God.

The six chapters follow six big ideas from his life and his book *The Soul's Journey into God*, written on a mountain called La Verna. We will not pretend the grown-up arguments are easy. We will tell them as a story you can carry.

Bonaventure taught in Paris, then led thousands of friars, then died in 1274 at a great church meeting in Lyon. People later called him the Seraphic Doctor — the teacher of burning love — the way they called Thomas Aquinas the Angelic Doctor, the teacher of clear sight. Two nicknames. Two ways of climbing. This booklet is the seraph's way, told small.

He was not a fairy-tale saint who never had a pile of letters. He was a school man who went to a mountain, and a mountain man who still had to govern a noisy family of brothers. If you have ever tried to think and pray on the same day, you are already on his path.

He died in 1274 at the Council of Lyon, the same year Thomas Aquinas died. Two doctors, two roads, one Church. This booklet will not flatten them into one nice man. It will let Bonaventure be Bonaventure: the seraph's student who still graded papers in his head.

A last picture before the chapters: a mountain, a lamp, a dish, a book. The mountain is La Verna, where he wrote the journey-book. The lamp is the borrowed light he said we think with. The dish is the story that he washed bowls even after they made him a cardinal — maybe true, maybe a tale that fits. The book is the world, which he said you should read without pretending it is God. If you remember those four, you can climb with him even when the grown-up words get heavy. The four pictures are enough for a week. The chapters will fill them in. Start with the mountain.

How to use this booklet

Read one chapter out loud if you can. Do not race. The Try This items are not homework for a grade. They are rungs. If a grown-up reads with you, let them take the Ask a Grown-Up question seriously. If you are reading alone, write the answer on paper and keep it.

You will hear the same six ideas in the older bands: mountain, footprint, inner image, Christ the hinge, climb-and-return, poverty as argument. The words get harder. The ladder does not change. That is the point of four bands at one table.

If a word is too big, ask. The grown-up bands use the same six ideas with harder words. You do not have to finish those yet. You only have to remember: look, ask, return.

A last honest note before Chapter 1. Bonaventure is not Francis in a professor's robe, and he is not Thomas in a brown cord. He is the man who tried to keep Francis's fire from burning the school down, and to keep the school from putting the fire out. Sometimes he held both. Sometimes the portrait went smooth. This booklet will not hide the smoothness. It will still invite you onto the ladder, because the ladder is real even when the painter is also a politician.

If you get lost, come back to three words: look, ask, return. Look at the world without pretending it is God. Ask for help at the door named Christ. Return to a job with quieter hands. That is the *Itinerarium* in a child's pocket. The older bands will argue about light, poverty, and whose Francis we inherited. You are allowed to grow into those fights without skipping the pocket version.

This booklet is free. Nobody is selling you a ladder. The grown-up who reads with you is the teacher. I am only the map-maker. If you remember only one picture, remember the six-winged seraph as a ladder you climb with looking, asking, and coming back to the dishes.

Chapter 1: The Mountain and the Six Wings



Illustration for Chapter 1

Imagine a rough mountain in Italy. Wind. Stone. A small place to pray. Years before Bonaventure came, Francis of Assisi had a vision there: a seraph — a burning angel — with six wings, in the shape of the crucified Christ. Francis's hands and side were marked. The mountain kept the story.

Bonaventure was the head of the Franciscan brothers when he went to that same mountain in 1259. He was tired of arguments and papers. He sat with Francis's vision until he saw a map inside it. Two wings pointing down: start with the world you can touch. Two wings pointing out: turn inside the soul. Two wings pointing up: God as one, and God as three. The face of the seraph was the end of the climb — not more facts, but love.

He wrote the map down. The book is called the *Itinerarium* — a journey-book. It is not a list of trivia. It is a path with rungs. You are invited onto it. You do not have to finish it today. You only have to know that thinking and praying can share one ladder.

Bonaventure had another name as a child: Giovanni. He grew up in Bagnoregio, a little town north of Rome. The old story says he was very sick, and Francis prayed, and someone said *O bona ventura* — “O good fortune.” Maybe the story is history. Maybe it is love remembering. Either way, the man who wrote the journey-book spent his life trying to hold Francis's fire and the school's careful words in one pair of hands.

If you have ever tried to draw a map of a feeling, you know why the six wings helped him. Feelings leak. Wings can be counted. Down, out, up. World, soul, God. He did not say you skip the bottom. He said you start where your feet are. That is why this chapter begins on stone and wind, not in a classroom with a gold star.

The journey-book has seven stops if you count the last one: six wings, then a darkness that is brighter than light. That last stop is not a scary closet. Bonaventure meant the kind of knowing that love does when words run out — like knowing you are safe in a parent's arms without a speech. You will meet that idea again when you are older. Today it is enough to know the map has an ending that is not a test.

Before the mountain, he had already been a teacher in Paris. Paris was the loudest school in Europe. Aristotle's books were arriving in Latin. Brothers argued in halls. Bonaventure used those books. He also said they were not the top of the ladder. The mountain did not make him stupid. It ordered what he already knew. First look. Then look inside. Then go through Christ. Then rest.

You can try a tiny version of that order this week. Look at one thing. Notice one feeling. Ask for help. That is not the whole *Itinerarium*. It is the first honest step on the same path.

Words to Remember

From the last chapter of the *Itinerarium* (Cousins translation): “Ask grace, not instruction; desire, not understanding; the groaning of prayer, not diligent reading.”

Plain English: when you get near the top of the ladder, you do not win by stacking more homework. You ask for help, and you want God more than you want to be the smartest person in the room.

Big Idea

Bonaventure's theology is a journey, not a pile of answers. The seraph's six wings are the rungs. A journey has weather. Some days you only name five things you can see. That still counts as a rung if you do not pretend it is the top.

Try This

1. Draw a ladder with six rungs. Label the bottom two "world," the middle two "inside," the top two "God." 2. Sit outside for three minutes. Name five things you can see. Do not explain them yet. Just name them. 3. Tell a grown-up one thing you wonder about God that is not a yes/no question.

Ask a Grown-Up

Why would someone write a thinking-book on a mountain instead of only in a library?

Chapter 2: The World Is a Footprint



Illustration for Chapter 2

Bonaventure said created things are *vestigis* — footprints. A footprint is not the person. It is a mark that someone passed by. A tree is not God. Light is not God. But if God made them, they carry a trace.

He also said the world is a book. You do not eat a book. You read it. If you only use a forest as wood, you have stopped reading. You have turned a sentence into scrap.

This is not the same as saying the tree *is* God. Bonaventure was careful. Vestige is not the source. Image is clearer. Likeness is closer still. Christ is the likeness. The climb goes from far-off traces to the One the traces belong to. That keeps the world holy without turning it into an idol.

For a child, the practice is simple and hard: look. Really look. A pebble, a bird, a loaf. Ask, “What does this show about the One who made it?” You may not get a speech back. Looking is already the first rung.

Bonaventure also wrote a small book about how the arts — making, speaking, counting, healing — all fold back toward God. He did not mean “only church songs count.” He meant a carpenter’s square and a singer’s scale can be rungs if you refuse to treat them as toys with no source. That is a grown idea in a child-size practice: when you draw, ask who gave color. When you add, ask who made two-and-two stay two-and-two. You do not have to stop drawing. You add a thank-you.

Think of a muddy shoe-print on a path after rain. You would not hug the print and call it your friend. You would say, “Someone walked here.” Bonaventure wanted that kind of seeing for rivers and stars. The river is not God. The river is a mark that the Maker is not stingy. Light is not God. Light is a clue that God likes to give.

People who love the earth sometimes worry that church talk makes the earth cheap. Bonaventure’s first rungs do the opposite. If the world is a footprint, you do not grind it into dust for fun. You also do not worship the print. You read, then you climb. Using a tree for a table can still be honest if you remember it was first a sentence in God’s book.

He wrote a short work whose title sounds like a machine: *The Reduction of the Arts to Theology*. Reduction here does not mean shrinking. It means folding every making-skill back toward God the way you fold a map so the whole country still shows. Counting, singing, healing, building — all of them can be rungs. None of them is the summit. If your school only teaches skills as tricks for winning, Bonaventure would say the book of the world has been ripped into flash cards.

Words to Remember

Bonaventure’s word: *vestige* — a footprint of God in the world.

Plain English: the world is a clue, not the treasure chest itself.

Big Idea

The material world is the first rung of the ladder, not an obstacle to throw away.

Try This

1. Choose one ordinary thing (a leaf, a cup, a stone). Draw it. Write one sentence: “This is not God, but it is a footprint because...” 2. On a walk, collect no trash from nature — only notice. Pick up litter if you see it. That is reading and caring at once. 3. Make a two-column list: “Using” vs “Reading” (example: chopping a tree / watching how it drinks light).

Ask a Grown-Up

When is it right to use something in the world, and when should we only look?

Chapter 3: Inside: Memory, Mind, and Wanting



Illustration for Chapter 3

After footprints outside, Bonaventure turns inward. He says the soul is an *image* of God — clearer than a tree, still not God. Medieval teachers named three powers: memory, intellect, will. Remembering. Understanding. Wanting.

You already use all three before breakfast. You remember yesterday. You figure out a puzzle. You want juice or justice or a hug. Bonaventure said those three are a dim picture of God's life — not because you are a tiny trinity, but because the soul is made to know and love.

He also said the picture is cracked. Wanting goes crooked. Memory lies. Understanding gets proud. That is why the middle of the journey cannot be “try harder inside.” The image needs repair.

For now, the child-work is to notice the three powers without showing off. Can you remember a kindness? Can you understand a rule? Can you want something good for someone else?

Bonaventure also said the mind does not see truth all by itself, the way a lamp does not light a room without oil. He called the extra light *illumination*. Grown-ups still argue about what that means. Some say God holds every true thought. Some say God made a good mind and lets it work. You do not have to pick a team. You only need this: when you know that two and two are four, or that hurting a friend is wrong, you are not the inventor of that light. You are standing in it.

Try a small test. Remember a face you love. Understand a rule that keeps someone safe. Want that person to have enough. Those three acts are not magic. They are the image doing its job. When they go crooked — when memory only keeps grudges, when understanding only shows off, when wanting only grabs — the image is smudged. Chapter 4 will say who can wash the smudge. This chapter only asks you to notice the three powers before you pretend you do not have them.

Bonaventure taught that memory can open onto forever, intellect onto truth, will onto goodness. Those are big words. A child-size version: when you remember a promise, you are touching more than yesterday. When you understand a fair rule, you are not inventing fairness. When you want good for someone who cannot pay you back, wanting has climbed a rung. The older booklet will argue with Thomas about how the light works. This band only asks you not to treat your mind as a toy you own.

Words to Remember

Bonaventure's word: *image* — the soul as a clearer reflection than a footprint.

Plain English: you are more like a portrait than a shoe-print — and portraits can be smudged.

Big Idea

Looking inside is the second movement of the journey: from the world to the soul.

Try This

1. Three cards: Remember / Understand / Want. On each, write one true example from today. 2. When you get angry, pause and name which power is loudest (memory of a hurt, a story you told yourself, a want). 3. Thank someone for a thing you remembered, not a thing you bought.

Ask a Grown-Up

Which is harder for you — remembering, understanding, or wanting the good — and why?

Chapter 4: The Hinge Named Jesus



Illustration for Chapter 4

The *Itinerarium* has a hinge. The first rungs can sound like a nature walk plus a feelings walk. Chapter 4 says the climb cannot finish that way. The image is broken. Christ — the perfect image who is also God — is the passage.

Bonaventure did not mean “be nice and Jesus is a sticker.” He meant the universe is Christ-shaped. The Word is the pattern things were made through. The Incarnation is not a patch on a ruined toy. It is the center the toy was made around.

You do not have to settle every grown-up fight between Bonaventure and Thomas Aquinas. You only need the hinge: you cannot complete the ladder by being clever alone. The middle of the map is a person.

A hinge is a small piece of metal that lets a heavy door move. Without it, you can push forever. Bonaventure put Christ at the fourth stage on purpose. Stages one through three look like something you could do with strong eyes and a quiet room. Stage four says the portrait is cracked, and cracked portraits do not fix themselves by staring harder.

Francis’s seraph was not a pretty bird. It was the crucified Christ with six wings. The mountain map is a cross-shaped map. That is why this chapter is not a prize for finishing the looking games. It is a door. You go through a Person.

Thomas, the other great teacher in Paris, talked about Christ as the one who heals what sin broke. Bonaventure agreed that sin is real. He also said Christ is not only the bandage. Christ is the pattern the world was cut from. Both teachers can sit at one table. This booklet will not make you choose a team at age eight. It will not let you skip the door either.

In the *Itinerarium*, the first three stages can sound like a nature club plus a feelings club. Stage four is the shock. The portrait is cracked. Grace is not extra credit. Bonaventure’s Francis on La Verna is not a mascot for “try harder.” The seraph is crucified. The ladder goes through a wound, not around it. You do not have to understand every grown word. You can remember the door.

Words to Remember

From the shape of *Itinerarium* chapter 4: the soul’s image cannot restore itself; the journey goes through Christ.

Plain English: the ladder has a door in the middle, and the door is not your grade in school.

Big Idea

Christ is not only a helper at the end. He is the center of the climb.

Try This

1. Draw the ladder again. Put a door on the fourth rung. Label it “Christ,” not “me trying harder.” 2. Read a short Gospel story (any one). Ask: is Jesus only fixing a mess, or also showing what the world was for? 3. Practice one small repair you cannot brag about (a hidden kindness).

Ask a Grown-Up

What is the difference between “Jesus helps me” and “Jesus is the center”?

Chapter 5: Mary and Martha on One Path



Illustration for Chapter 5

In Luke's story, Martha serves and worries. Mary sits and listens. Jesus says Mary chose the better part. Some people heard: sitting is holy, serving is second-class.

Franciscans could not live that split. They prayed on mountains and walked into towns. Bonaventure was a professor and then the Minister General — a mystic with a pile of letters and a divided order to hold together. He said contemplation is first, but it is for the return. You climb, then you come back with new eyes, then you serve.

The journey is a circle: world → God → world again. Staying on the mountaintop forever is not the Franciscan end. Serving with no climb is exhaustion.

If you have ever been told to “just sit still” when your body wanted to help, you know Martha's feeling. If you have ever been told to “stop dreaming and do something” when you needed quiet, you know Mary's. Bonaventure refused to pick one sister and throw the other out of the house. Listen first. Then work with listening still in your hands.

He wrote that theology is not only a pile of true sentences. It is a practical science — ordered to changing the soul, and then the street. A friar who only prays and never shares bread has not finished the journey. A friar who only shares bread and never prays will run out of bread and of love.

You can practice the circle in a small house. Ten minutes of quiet is not laziness if it is for the return. A chore is not holiness if it is only worry with extra steps. Climb. Return. Climb again tomorrow.

Bonaventure's own week looked like that circle whether he liked it or not. Letters. Arguments. Hungry brothers. Then the mountain in 1259, then more letters. If he had stayed on La Verna forever, the Order would have split without a shepherd. If he had never gone, the letters would have been only worry. Mary and Martha are not two career tracks. They are two beats of one heart.

Words to Remember

Luke 10:42: “Mary has chosen the better part.” (NABRE sense: listening is not laziness.)

Plain English: sit first so your serving is not just worry with extra steps.

Big Idea

Prayer and work belong on one path. Climb, then return.

Try This

1. Ten minutes of quiet (no screen), then one helpful job. Notice if the job feels different. 2. Make a paper circle: Climb / Return. Put a mark where you spent yesterday. 3. Help someone without announcing it.

Ask a Grown-Up

When do you rest so you can work, and when do you work so you never rest?

Chapter 6: Poor as a Path, Not a Contest



Illustration for Chapter 6

Francis lived poor in a fierce, immediate way. Clare fought for years to own nothing. Bonaventure, as leader, had to keep an order from tearing itself in two. Some brothers wanted absolute poverty. Some wanted a softer house. Bonaventure said poverty is a *means*: it frees you to preach, serve, and contemplate. Clare's accent is different: poverty as an end, a space God fills.

This booklet will not pick a winner for you. The tension is part of the family. Bonaventure's *Major Life* of Francis is also an interpretation — a portrait that supports a mission, not a camera.

If you are a child, the practice is not “own nothing.” It is: notice what owning does to your wanting. Share. Leave a margin. Do not make poverty a costume.

Imagine two kitchens. In one, the table is empty because the family is waiting for God to be enough. In the other, the table is simple so people can leave quickly to help. Clare's kitchen sounds more like the first. Bonaventure's sounds more like the second. Both kitchens can be holy. Both can fake it. Empty hands that mock other people's empty hands are not Franciscan. Full hands that never open are not either.

Bonaventure had to feed thousands of brothers and still call them poor. That is a hard job. Some later brothers said he made Francis too tame. Some said he saved the family from splitting. You are allowed to feel the tug. A living argument is better than a slogan you cannot live.

Do not dress in rags for a play and call it holiness. Give away one extra. Notice the grab in your wanting. That is enough for this band.

Later, some people said Bonaventure ordered older Francis stories put away so his *Major Life* would be the only portrait. Scholars still argue about that. What is sure is this: for a long time, the Francis most people met was Bonaventure's Francis — the Christ-imitator whose poverty served a mission. The rawer Francis of the early memories came back into print centuries later. A child does not have to solve that. A child can learn that a portrait is not a photograph, and still love the face.

Words to Remember

Bonaventure's accent: poverty as a means for the mission, not the whole mission.

Plain English: empty hands can help you walk; empty hands are not the only destination.

Big Idea

Franciscan poverty is a living argument, not a single slogan.

Try This

1. Give away one extra thing this week. Notice the feeling without making a speech. 2. Write two sentences: “Poverty as end...” and “Poverty as means...” Ask which scares you. 3. Count advertisements you see in one hour. What are they trying to make you want?

Ask a Grown-Up

What is something our house owns that we could live without — and what would that free us to do?

For the Grown-Up Reader

This elementary booklet follows Harry’s Bonaventure pack (32 files, August 2026): *Itinerarium* structure (1.1, 3.3), vestige/image/likeness (2.2), Christ as center (2.3), illumination named but not settled (2.4, 7.1), Mary/Martha (2.5), poverty as means vs Clare’s end (2.6, 7.2), *Legenda Maior* as interpretation (1.4, 7.3). Primary text: Bonaventure, *Itinerarium Mentis in Deum* (1259), trans. Ewert Cousins (Paulist, 1978) and Zachary Hayes (Franciscan Institute). Secondary: Christopher M. Cullen, *Bonaventure* (Oxford, 2006); Zachary Hayes, *The Hidden Center* (1981); Malcolm Lambert, *Franciscan Poverty*; David Burr, *The Spiritual Franciscans*; Jacques Dalarun on the hagiography problem.

The childhood *bona ventura* story is flagged as tradition, not proven fact. Birth year 1217 or 1221 left open. No composite sage. Disagreements with Aquinas (illumination; Christ as remedy vs center) and with Clare (poverty as end vs means) stay open. The booklet does not pretend the *Legenda Maior* is a camera. Quotes used as quotes: *Itinerarium* 7 (Cousins) and Luke 10:42. Other Bonaventure language (*vestige*, *image*, seraph structure) is taught as his vocabulary, not as invented speeches. I did not invent dialogue.

If a child asks whether Bonaventure “won” against the Spirituals, the honest answer is: he kept an Order from splitting, and some fire went out of the portrait. That is a cost, not a cartoon villain.

About WisdomForge

WisdomForge makes the same figures in four bands — elementary, middle, high, adult — so a bright child and a grown reader can share a table without sharing a lecture. This is the youngest band. The older bands add the illumination debate, the *Legenda Maior* problem, and the university quarrel. Free to read. No payment.